EVOLUTION, 1971–84

One of the critical shortcomings identified in 1971 was the Indian Army's relative lack of mechanization and the need to orient itself towards offensive tasks. In June 1972, HQ Northern Command was raised to oversee the northern borders with Pakistan and China, with the existing XV Corps and the newly raised XVI Corps forming part of it; 10 and 26 Infantry divisions were transferred from XV Corps to XVI Corps. On 15 July 1972, 16 Infantry Division was formed by reorganizing the ad hoc Foxtrot Sector active during the 1971 war. In 1975, 31 Armoured Division was established, followed by 18 Infantry and 21 Mountain divisions in 1976, 22 and 24 Infantry divisions in 1978 and HQ X Corps at Bathinda on 1 July 1979.

The transformation to a mechanized army received an impetus with the raising of the Mechanised Infantry Regiment on 2 April 1979: 14 infantry battalions (1 MADRAS; 1 JAT LI; 1/8 GORKHA RIFLES; 1 SIKH; 14 KUMAON; 1 GARH RIF; 1 DOGRA; 7 PUNJAB; 7 GRENADIERS; 20 MARATHA LI; 18 RAJ RIF; 16 MAHAR; 18 RAJPUT; 16 J&K RIF) were equipped with OT-62 TOPAS, OT-64 SKOT and BTR-60 armoured personnel carriers, from 1982 replaced with BMP-1 IFVs. A fourth type of division was introduced – the Reorganised Army Plains Infantry Division (RAPID) with two infantry brigades and a mechanized brigade composed of armoured regiment(s) and mechanized-infantry battalions with the requisite mechanized combat-support elements. Four infantry divisions (14, 18, 24 and 36) would be converted to the RAPID role in 1985.

As part of the transformation process, 33 Mechanised Division was established at Hisar on 15 November 1982, although it was converted into an armoured division in December 1993. Along with these changes came the designation of I and II corps as 'strike corps', with each being allotted an armoured division and two or more infantry divisions. These corps were to be tasked with any offensive tasks while the other corps were expected to act as 'pivot', or holding, corps. A helicopter-equipped air-assault division